Clever children, because they pick things up quickly, then very quickly become themselves. So they start to deviate from the average. You can see how their inquisitiveness begins to make individuals of them, because they are looking for unusual things in their environment, things that their peers wouldn't even begin to notice. So much of what I'm telling you now is about the children, but also about myself: even today, I constantly want to find the unexpected thing in a room or in a person. Jean Renoir once said that in every imaginable situation there's the perfect shot: it could be through a glass or from behind someone's head. The job is to find it. That's my instinct, anyhow, and it's an instinct I love in other people.

I'm sure I felt I was in preparation for something. Not to play a giant personal part – that wasn't the intention – but to bring the experience I was gathering, and the expertise I had gained, into forming an organisation that might itself guarantee the pursuit of justice in public affairs, despite the aura of complacency that so often surrounds them. You could say, without too much sentiment, I hope, that the stars were coming into alignment for that organisation. I began to feel the pulse of them, the possibility and the stars, during a trip to see a total solar eclipse in the Australian desert at the end of 2002. We were physicists, and the tradition of skywatching in that discipline remains a thrilling part of the game. We worked out that the eclipse would be at its best over a 7.5-kilometre track for thirty-eight seconds, and that we'd want to be at the centre of that track for the duration.

A team of us, about twelve cars in all, headed off for this three-and-a-half-day drive to find a little patch of desert. In the event, we would have to be so precise in our predictions that we'd be standing on only one piece of ground, no more than half a kilometre long, and for this I laid out a great deal of expenditure and came near to exhaustion. But the philosophical impact was very great on me at the time: I finally realised that if you believe something is true, and you weigh and measure the possibilities well, and you carry on with good faith, then your prediction will come good. I had put myself into the project entirely and trusted our powers in conjunction with the intellectual traditions we had studied. And it was the right thing to do.

Stick with me. Behind the setting up of WikiLeaks was not only the experience of a life, and the lives of others, but also an experience of thinking my way towards clarity about human rights. There is no way to give you an honest and good book without going into those ideas. I have